

2026 CHRO Priority: Transform HR Through AI

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HR is at a strategic crossroads where it must either reinvent itself to deliver value in the AI era or face potential dissolution. To harness AI and revolutionize HR, CHROs must align their HR strategy and tech roadmap with enterprise goals and AI ambition; develop a clear vision and roadmap for a reinvented, AI-infused HR operating model; and establish triggers — such as new technology development — to regularly review and adjust their HR strategy.

Analysis

Figure 1: HR is at an AI-Led Inflection Point

Why Now | HR is at an AI-Led Inflection Point

HR is at a strategic crossroads where it either reinvents itself to deliver business value in the AI era or faces potential dissolution.



Source: Gartner
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AI is reshaping how organizations operate, and the HR function is not immune to its transformational impact. AI pilots and early implementations abound. In fact, 95% of CHROs indicate their organization has undertaken one or more AI-related initiatives.¹ It's an exciting moment for CHROs to not just ensure HR can do things faster, better and cheaper with AI but to fundamentally redefine the value proposition of the HR function.

However, with this opportunity comes increased pressure from executive leadership to elevate HR's operational performance. Yet, many CHROs feel unprepared for the scale of transformation required. For example, only 23% of board directors agree their CHRO effectively integrates AI considerations into their HR strategy, while only 36% of CHROs are prepared to, or are already, incorporating AI into HR's operating model.^{1,2}

AI offers HR the unique opportunity to shift from being a facilitator of talent processes to a true architect of enterprise transformation — by leading work redesign that aligns with business strategy. However, traditional approaches to HR transformation will not work in an environment where enterprise change has become ungovernable and where human work constantly shifts. Especially not when AI compounds change further as it learns and distributes knowledge.

To thrive in the AI era, CHROs must outline a clear and compelling AI strategy for both the work HR does and how the HR operates — or risk undermining HR's strategic relevance. This involves creating a defined vision statement, a roadmap for embedding AI in the function and evolving the HR operating model, and a plan to prepare HR talent for new ways of working.

Gartner's Positions

- AI plays for efficiency only produce marginal gains. Progressive CHROs fast-track AI in strategic talent activities, such as organizational design and strategic workforce planning.
- By 2030, AI will execute 50% of current HR activities, fundamentally transforming HR's work and roles.
- CHROs should be aware of vendor "agentic AI-washing;" most vendors are rebranding virtual assistant and chatbot products as agentic AI to capture buyers' attention.
- HR functions that don't integrate AI into their operating model will be sidelined as a nonessential function.
- HR's mandate needs to expand beyond enabling the workforce to enabling how work gets done.

Your Journey as a Chief Human Resources Officer

HR must develop an operating model that can "incubate" deeper expertise on workforce issues and do so dynamically as new issues arise, using technologies to draw in knowledge from the wider organization, simulate solution options and distribute expertise out to managers. To accomplish these objectives, CHROs must execute five critical steps:

- Create and deploy an HR strategy that supports AI transformation and enterprise goals
- Redesign the HR operating model and HR roles for the AI era
- Identify high-value AI and technology use cases across HR
- Analyze the vendor landscape for AI and technology use cases across HR
- Build a governance framework to measure and evolve the AI-in-HR strategy

Journey Step: Create and Deploy an HR Strategy That Supports AI Transformation and Enterprise Goals

To transform and increase effectiveness, build a vision and strategy for your HR function to support and embrace AI, both within HR and the enterprise.

Featured Insights Supporting This Journey Step

- [Top Insights on AI for CHROs](#)
- [Gartner AI Opportunity Radar: Set Your Enterprise's AI Ambition](#)
- [AI Can't Be an Afterthought in HR Strategy](#)
- [Create an AI Strategy for Your HR Organization](#)

Journey Step: Redesign the HR Operating Model and HR Roles for the AI Era

Redefine the HR operating model, skills and roles for the AI era.

Featured Insights Supporting This Journey Step

- [The Impact of AI on the HR Operating Model](#)
- [Choose the Best HR Operating Model for an AI-Enabled Enterprise](#)
- [Playbook: Preparing the Transformation to an AI-Infused HR Operating Model](#)

Journey Step: Identify High-Value AI and Technology Use Cases Across HR

Investigate the highest-value AI and technology use cases across HR and prioritize those best aligned with organizational and strategic objectives.

Featured Insights Supporting This Journey Step

- [AI Use-Case Assessment for HR](#)
- [AI Use Case and Best Practice Library for HR](#)
- [Understand the Impact of AI Across HR Processes to Accelerate HR Transformation](#)

Journey Step: Analyze the Vendor Landscape for AI and Technology Use Cases Across HR

Analyze existing AI capabilities within your HR tech stack, as well as complementary capabilities and AI tools in the market, to cut through the hype in a fast-moving technology market.

Featured Insights Supporting This Journey Step

- [Framework for Evaluating AI Capabilities in HCM Suites](#)
- [How HR Tech Leaders Can Make HR Data AI-Ready](#)
- [7 Factors to Assess HR AI Agent Capabilities](#)

Journey Step: Build a Governance Framework to Measure and Evolve the AI in HR Strategy

Determine the effort and resources needed for AI deployment, factor in technology costs and pricing models, and calculate hard and soft benefits from AI investments to drive continued success in an evolving AI era.

Featured Insights Supporting This Journey Step

- [Getting Started with AI Agents in HR](#)
- [Address 5 Gaps to Unlock HR AI Agent Success](#)
- [AI in HCM Suites: Evolution, Use Cases and Pricing](#)
- [Three Steps to Implement Adaptive Data Governance in HR](#)

Please click here for more information on this mission-critical priority: [Transform HR Through AI](#).

Evidence

¹ 2025 Gartner Q4 AI and HR Function CHRO Survey

² 2025 Gartner Board of Directors Talent Survey

2025 Gartner Q4 AI and HR Function CHRO Survey. This survey was conducted to gain insights into CHRO perspectives on the current state of AI within their organizations and HR functions, as well as to collect up-to-date information on HR functional transformation. The research was conducted online from 17 November to 16 December, 2025, and contains responses from 110 heads of HR with representation from various geographies, industries, and functions. Disclaimer: The results of this survey do not represent global findings or the market as a whole, but reflect the sentiments of the respondents and companies surveyed.

The 2025 Gartner Board of Directors Talent Survey was conducted to understand how boards engage with executive leadership, their priorities around talent and workforce issues, the role and effectiveness of the CHRO, approaches to CEO succession planning, and the impact of AI on talent and board decision-making. The research was conducted online from 28 August through 24 September 2025 amongst 200 board of directors, with representation across regions, industries, ownership types, and organization sizes globally. The survey was designed and developed by Gartner's HR practice research team. Disclaimer: The results of this survey do not represent global findings or the market as a whole, but reflect the sentiments of the respondents and companies surveyed.

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